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BOOK REVIEW

Janet Y. Chen. (2023). *The sounds of Mandarin: Learning to speak a national language in China and Taiwan, 1913–1960*. Columbia University Press. 412 pp. ISBN 9780231209038

Reviewed by Norbert Francis (Northern Arizona University)

How do languages become national by motivating diverse populations, in this case massively, to converge on a target of learning? The study by Professor Chen begins with the period in Chinese history following the 1911 Revolution that marked the beginning of a great social and linguistic turning point: the New Culture Movement, precursor of the May Fourth Movement of 1919. Hu Shi, writing the prescient essay “Constructive literary revolution — A literature of national speech” in a 1918 number of *New Youth*, called for the wide-ranging reform of language and writing: “Speak in the language of the time in which you live” — baihua 白話 (clear speech, plain speech). The reference was to what is often called the “vernacular.” One might ask in hindsight, for the sake of clarity, which language was this “vernacular,” or in other words: to which language, specifically, did this “vernacular” belong? As the book outlines in detail, the pathway to fully realizing the reform across the provinces would turn out to be steep and protracted.

Along another but related dimension, as the title suggests, there is an underlying reason for the emphasis on the patterns of sound in a study about the learning of language. From both the biological and the cultural points of view, central to the design of linguistic systems are its sonorous qualities. Two examples are relevant to these perspectives: why sign languages have an analogue to phonology, and culturally, why modern Chinese characters are not ideographic. The sound pattern of languages (specific languages with a name) matter. Other linguistic subsystems are at the center, or at the core, of language, and they interface with phonology.

The historical account of language unification — how it appears throughout the chapters often as torturously difficult and conflictive — is what captures our attention most of all as a theme. In fact, language policy and planning in China and Taiwan seem rather like representative cases of failure. But readers here need to recheck, on the cover, the dates in the subtitle of the book “1923–1960.” *The sounds of Mandarin* traces what might have been the “constructive revolution” of Hu Shi through two historical times of cataclysm, ending in 1960, to leave for further discussion the third impending total collapse of culture, the years of mayhem and educational ruin that would finally come to an end in 1976. It seemed as if

the chaos of the third historical time, the Cultural Revolution, would only subside with the death of the tyrant who kept it going for so many years.

Briefly, and making sure to keep the main topic of the book in mind, we should remind ourselves of the ongoing political and military circumstances during which each educational initiative was charged with promoting the learning of a national language and literacy. Chapters 1, 2, 3 and 5 help remind us of the dire conditions. The Republican Era of almost permanent civil war, interspersed by short periods of respite, managed to assemble a number of cultural projects prior to the invasion of Northeast China (1931) and full scale invasion and occupation ending in 1945. The author spares us the details of the total material and human cost for the 34 years, in particular after 1937. From its temporary capital in Sichuan, under constant bombardment, the work of promoting *guoyu* precariously continued. Chapter 3, “The national language in exile,” covers these years. The National Language Committee continued to conduct research and surveys, provided guidance and training to teachers, edited a new rhyming dictionary... [to be] “interrupted by hasty retreat” (p.136).

The revolution of 1949, following the second civil war of the 20th Century, also promising language reform, would be incapable of making meaningful progress. The decade of the 1950s ended with the Anti-Rightist Campaign political persecution and the hecatomb of the Great Leap Forward. The section “Leaping forward” of Chapter 5 reports on the “miracles,” how in 1958 the mountain village of Wushan in Fujian undertook the “arduous battle of fifty days and nights,” 85% of youths and 60% of middle aged adults achieving mastery of *putonghua*. In communities of Guangdong, victory was pronounced “within ten days” of launching the “assault” (p.268). During the early 1960s, following recognition of failure, a possible short recovery in language and literacy education is soon consumed by ten years of revolutionary culture. Miracles aside, it would be surprising to find consistent or valid evidence for any measurable progress at all in language learning during this period. Estimates would have been about as reliable as those of the ultimate tensile strength of steel produced by backyard furnaces in 1959 or of tendencies in university professor course evaluation as a function of student achievement in 1968.

As a contrast, the slow but nevertheless steady progress on standardization in Taiwan is interesting to study considering both prior linguistic diversity among the Chinese and Austronesian languages and widespread speaking ability and literacy in Japanese. In some ways, the provocative question for our topic (in Chapter 4) is the language shift associated with (or simply coinciding with) the democratic reform inaugurated by the election of 1996. The seemingly contradictory outcome regarding the relationship between official *guoyu* and majority-speaking Minnanyu, for example, requires a study of its own, introduced by this

chapter. As one-party rule came to an end, the new pluralistic political system gave rise to the promotion of linguistic pluralism. While the previous regime was associated with the imposition of Mandarin Chinese, the new language policy extended recognition within the educational system and material support broadly to the languages that had previously experienced discrimination. Nevertheless, evidence strongly suggests that if anything, the historical shift toward Mandarin – that is, at the expense of the other languages, not “in addition to” – has accelerated over the twenty-five years of democracy and linguistic opening (Liu et al., 2016). Confirming, or disconfirming, evidence to the cited study and similar findings by other researchers is still needed. On a related note – alluded to indirectly in the chapter (p.171) and in the Epilogue (p.288) – future studies might examine the factors that account for how *guoyu*, in Taiwan, and Mainland *putonghua* have evolved in parallel, forming arguably a common, mutually intelligible, dialect of Mandarin.

Chapter 5 makes several mentions of the third leg of language-literacy reform, the breakthrough in romanization, making *zhuyin fuhao* effectively obsolete (p.222) in China. The importance for learning and, later, for information processing, of *hanyu pinyin* cannot be underestimated. Consider, for example, the extended application throughout East Asia of the system developed by Zhou Youguang, for example the widely used informal method *Vietnamese pinyin* for second language learning of Chinese. A growing sub-field of research, work on the relationship between the character system and the different pinyin scripts, promises to make an important contribution to the science of literacy learning generally. In this context (the expansion of literacy), telling might be the estimate, in Mainland China, of the number of proficient speakers of the national language, from one period to the next: at 53% in 2000 and 70% in 2013 (pp.1–3). Then according to Xinhua, quoting the Ministry of Education, it was 80% in 2023. With the current estimated literacy rate at above 95%, it is plausible to project within the present decade, that among young adults who have completed at least middle school that proficiency in *putonghua* will be virtually universal, if it is not so already. Estimates in Taiwan suggest an even more rapid shift in recent years, among young people, toward the national language.

The above estimate by no means implies that the national language of China and of Taiwan, and one of the two major, among the four official, languages of Singapore, must replace any other spoken language in its emergence as the common language of the nation. It should go without saying that the inevitable attainment of common-national language does not require societal monolingualism, concept or proposal that the book implicitly seems to favor. Related to this idea is the more complicated empirical question of how successful speech communities of minority languages can be in preserving their historic mother tongue as part of a stable

societal bilingualism. This last question needs to be deferred for a more extensive discussion as the interaction among the relevant factors is complex.

Especially for serious students of language learning, the descriptions of early teaching method — keeping in mind that, internationally, the state of the art before the 1950s was largely prescientific — are interesting (79, 165, 186–187). If approaches to second language teaching associated with the so-called “direct method” turned out to be more like “submersion” (no input modification or context-embedding or scaffolding — the opposite of “immersion”), even “repeat after me” would have been an improvement. In turn, what the main features of the method termed “dialect comparative” aren’t exactly clear; but if it depended on a kind of concurrent translating on the part of teachers, progress would have been even more precarious. Regardless, it was television — one set per hundred in 1978, ten years later in 73% of households (p.284) — that decisively provided learners with the requisite “comprehensible input” for second language learning.

Throughout the chapters, readers might call attention to what appears as a somewhat idiosyncratic use of the terms: speech, accent, dialect, language. But here the author is following common usage (indeed ubiquitous and accepted in Mainland China, even as many linguists will beg to differ). The copy editor at Columbia University Press would probably also object to the technically correct and unwieldy alternatives — “language of the Chinese family of languages,” to refer for example to Minnanyu, Hakka and Cantonese. In reality, most of the time, the debate, or discussion, about the proper use of the terms “dialect” and “language” is not particularly interesting as long as we use the terminology (including related terms) consistently and, in a normal and polite discussion, everyone knows what everyone else is referring to. An example of inconsistency (e.g., related to political motivation) would be the assigning of “dialect” to a minority language that lacks a writing system used by its speakers. Typically, linguists in Mainland China, to their credit, will apply the categories consistently. Thus, within the family of Sino-Tibetan languages of the Chinese branch, including Mandarin, all would be *dialects*,¹ or “dialect groups,” and languages spoken in China of the Tibeto-Burman branch — Yi, Tibetan, Qiang, etc. — are called *languages*. Consistently again, this way of categorizing applies to languages belonging to other families, such as Uyghur.

1. Of course, one of these “dialects,” as much as it feels odd to call it that today, has become the true national, 國 (guo), language, 語 (yu), overriding theme of this book, for how it happened. Tsu (2022) links this historical achievement to the digital revolution that made the reading and especially the writing of characters just as easy (once you learn them) as it is with any other writing system.

The Epilogue ends on a tentative note. As a historical study, the assessment of the course of convergence toward a national language as advancing toward an “elusive goal” (p. 294) corresponds accurately to the years we mainly focused on, in the past tense. At the same time, the detailed accounts of the teaching and learning strategies and the language policy and planning schemes of this period are important to review closely for understanding them better, for a number of good reasons.

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Address for correspondence

Norbert Francis
College of Education
Northern Arizona University
Flagstaff, Arizona 86011
United States

norbert.francis@nau.edu



<https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7941-0883>

Publication history

Date received: 26 December 2023

Date accepted: 10 March 2024

Published online: 29 November 2024